

‘Not to make an attempt with SLI would be a crime’

NRAI president Kalikesh Singh Deo on the Shooting League of India’s vision, format innovations, esports plans, and **navigating** a crowded sports market.

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Even as an 11-year-old top sporting league gasps under the crushing weight of a failing contractual framework and another can’t pay salaries months after its conclusion, a new entrant steps into the fray — the Shooting League of India (SLI).

Bold, new, and ready to take its first shot in New Delhi on November 20, the 11-day competition is the latest to elbow its way into an already saturated landscape of homegrown leagues.

However, its backers are undeterred. Kalikesh Narayan Singh Deo, president of the National Rifle Association of India (NRAI), calls it an ‘exciting adventure.’

Sportstar sat down with the man fronting the federation’s newest gamble to understand whether the NRAI is truly ready to harness this fresh wave.

In a competitive market, with sporting leagues mushrooming

across the country, what novelties does the SLI have to offer?

With the massively growing popularity of shooting in India, where for every competition, you have 10,000–20,000 people participating across the spectrum, it is an opportune time for the league to come in. This is a first-of-its-kind effort that introduces a new format. It will also potentially transgress to people who have been a part of shooting in different ways.

Do you remember the first toy you got as a child? A lot of us got small guns to play with. So, shooting has been an endemic part of our childhood in many ways — through movies, video games, and in some cases, the sport itself.

We have picked a mixed team format, and to begin with, we are looking to have anywhere from four to eight franchises. There’s an exciting adventure ahead of us.

How does the league plan on integrating esports? The NRAI’s SLI FAQ document does talk about a hybrid model integrating traditional shooting events with

virtual competitions.

We are talking to technology partners to integrate a virtual aspect of the sport into our league. Whether it forms the mainstay of the league or not is yet to be decided, but certainly the idea is to capture audiences beyond the traditional shooting viewership. Let’s not forget you may have one lakh shooters registered in India, but you will have maybe 100 crore who are gaming and doing stuff like that.

Shooting, not as dynamic as most other sports, has never been spectator-friendly. So, for social media and television, is there a snappier plan to reel in viewers?

We will look at innovative things the audience can relate to, like the pressure on a shooter, the release of the trigger, and an athlete’s mannerisms. There will be data, graphics, VR, feedback from the shooters, biorhythms, and more. What will happen because of that is that the audience will understand and feel the excitement of performing. Couple that with the loyalty they would have with a